



dedication paid off as Gukesh clinched the Candidates tournament, paving the way for the World championship. "It required a lot of effort, but we did our best, and it worked," Klimkowski said.

By late November, while Keymer was working remotely with Radek and Harikrishna from Manilva, a small town in the southernmost province of Spain, Klimkowski was playing a tournament 11,000 km away in Singapore, close to Gukesh but not actively helping him there.

Strategic mastery and novelty

Gukesh's triumph over Ding was marked by his ability to deploy surprises and novelties that threw his opponent off balance. Ding, though accurate under time pressure, often found himself outprepared.

Keymer explained their strategy: "The goal was to surprise Ding early, ensuring Gukesh had the advantage of familiarity with the lines and evaluation while getting Ding out of preparation. It wasn't just about finding sharp ideas with White, it was about getting a fighting game and maintaining momentum. That strategy worked very well," Keymer said.

Beyond engine-assisted preparation, Klimkowski emphasised the importance of practical, human-centred insights. "A human touch is critical. If a player doesn't understand a position from engine preparation, they can easily misplay

it. Sometimes, it's better to opt for a less optimal but more practical line — something a good Second should know," he noted.

The team faced criticism from Magnus Carlsen, who questioned their preparation for Game 12, where Ding secured a crucial win to equalise the match. Keymer addressed the scrutiny, defending their approach.

"I believe it's very clear that this line was relatively dangerous for Black. We changed c4-e5 to c4-e6 and Gukesh had to revise an incredible number of lines for this. We also have to understand that no matter how much work we, as Seconds, do for him, he only has a limited amount of time he can spend on preparation. Otherwise, he will not be able to keep up that same level of play for three weeks if he prepares five hours every day — it's simply not going to work," said Keymer.

"So, we always had to make sure to give him as little as possible but everything he needed to know," he added. Not to be overlooked is South African mental health coach Paddy Upton, who worked tremendously to help Gukesh maintain his composure and resilience under immense pressure.

With a team of brilliant minds and indefatigable support, Gukesh's victory seemed destined. Like Captain America calling on the Avengers to fight, Gukesh's team too assembled for the final showdown.

